THE 7-DAY PLAN

THE ZOBO RESET

7 DAYS

Bloated and sluggish after the party? Here's the plan to feel light again, using the drink you already have at home.

Any celebration. One drink. Your body back.

the honest BODY.

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THE HONEST BODY

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Before You Start

This is a 7-day plan for the days after a celebration, when your body feels heavy, puffy and slow. It uses zobo, ordinary Nigerian food, water, sleep and a little walking. No pills, no starving, nothing you can't buy at the market.

CHECK WITH YOUR DOCTOR FIRST IF…

You are pregnant or trying to get pregnant. Hibiscus is commonly advised against in pregnancy. Please don't follow this plan until after your baby is born, and ask your doctor or midwife first.

You are breastfeeding. Ask your doctor or midwife before starting.

You take blood pressure medicine. Hibiscus can lower blood pressure, and together with your medicine it could bring it down too far.

You have diabetes or take medicine for blood sugar. Hibiscus may lower blood sugar.

You have kidney or liver disease, or you take any regular medicine. Hibiscus can interact with some medicines.

You usually have low blood pressure, or you feel dizzy or faint during the plan. Stop and drink plain water.

SEE A DOCTOR INSTEAD OF DOING A RESET IF…

Your bloating lasts more than two weeks, you have strong stomach pain, blood in your stool, vomiting, or you are losing weight without trying. These need a proper check, not a drink.

HOW TO READ THIS

Read Chapters 1 to 3 today, make your first batch of zobo tonight, and start Day 1 tomorrow morning. The Quick Reference at the back is the page to screenshot.

AN HONEST WORD ON THE SCIENCE

Hibiscus has been studied, and some results are promising. But many studies are small or were done on animals, so this book says "may" and "research suggests" where that is the truth. Most of what you will feel comes from the whole plan together: less salt, less alcohol, more fibre, more water, better sleep and a daily walk. Zobo is the anchor that makes the plan easy to follow. This book is general information, not medical advice.

INTRODUCTION: Let's Be Honest About What Celebrations Do to Your Body

Nigeria is not short of reasons to celebrate. Christmas. Eid. Easter. New Year. Wedding season. Naming ceremonies. Owambe Saturdays that somehow run into Sunday. Detty December. End-of-year parties that bleed into January. There is always something.

And at every one of those celebrations, the food is serious. Jollof at every party. Pepper soup at every gathering. Small chops, chin chin, puff puff, malt, beer, palm wine, and enough fried meat to feed a compound. You eat. You drink. You stay up until 2am, wake up, and do it again.

Nobody goes into a celebration thinking about the recovery. That's fine. That's the whole point.

But a few days later, your body starts talking. Your stomach feels heavy. Your jeans won't sit right. Your energy is on the floor. You feel sluggish in a way that sleep doesn't fix. And you're looking at your kitchen wondering what you're supposed to do about it.

Here's the thing: you don't need a foreign detox plan. You don't need to order anything. You already have the reset tool at home.

Zobo, the drink you've known since childhood, is made from dried hibiscus petals. It is rich in natural antioxidants, it has a mild water-releasing effect, and it is cheap and easy to make. Unsweetened, it is a far better choice than the soft drinks, malt and alcohol your body has been handling for weeks.

This guide gives you a 7-day plan built around zobo, real food and your body's natural recovery. No starving. No extreme restriction. No ingredients you can't find at the market. Just a clear daily plan that works with your body, not against it.

THE WHOLE IDEA

Your body already knows how to recover. For seven days, you stop getting in its way and start giving it what it needs. Zobo makes that easy to stick to.

CHAPTER 1: Why Your Body Feels the Way It Does

Before you start, it helps to understand what happened inside your body during the celebrations. Not to feel guilty about it. Just to understand what you're working with.

The bloating

Most post-party bloating isn't fat. It's mostly two things: water retention and gas. Both usually settle quickly once you give your body the right support.

Salt is the main culprit. Party food in Nigeria is heavily seasoned. Seasoning cubes, stockfish, smoked fish, crayfish, suya spice, the fried rice base. All of it is high in salt. When there's a lot of salt in your system, your body holds on to extra water. That's where the puffiness comes from: your face, your belly, the feeling that your fingers are slightly swollen.

The gas comes from the mix. Fizzy drinks, heavy starch and oily food, eaten late and at odd times, give your gut more than it can handle comfortably. Trapped gas is the result.

The sluggishness

Your liver handles everything you consume: alcohol, fat, sugar, the additives in packaged drinks. A few weeks of party eating gives it a heavy workload, and you feel it as tiredness and fog, even after sleeping.

Your gut also notices. A few weeks of low-fibre, high-sugar, alcohol-heavy eating can upset the balance of bacteria in your digestive system, and that can show up as low energy and a heavy stomach. It's not weakness. It's biology.

Why starving yourself doesn't fix it

Many people respond to post-party heaviness by skipping meals or drinking only water. That often makes you feel worse. Your body, coming off a period of excess, needs nutrients to repair, fibre to keep things moving, and enough food to keep your energy steady.

THE BOTTOM LINE

Your body is holding extra fluid, your digestion is behind, and your liver has been working overtime. None of it is permanent. Seven days of sensible eating, water, sleep and zobo will help bring you back to how you felt before the celebrations.

CHAPTER 2: What Zobo Can (and Can't) Do

You've been drinking this your whole life. Here's what it may actually be doing inside your body, and where the evidence stops.

Zobo is made from *Hibiscus sabdariffa*, the dried red calyx of the hibiscus plant. That deep red colour comes from anthocyanins, the same family of antioxidants found in blueberries and pomegranates. The difference is that zobo leaves cost very little at any Nigerian market.

What the research suggests

It may support healthy blood pressure. Several human studies found that hibiscus tea modestly lowered blood pressure in people with mildly raised readings. It also has a mild diuretic effect, which means it may help your body let go of some extra water. (This is also why people on blood pressure medicine must check with a doctor first.)

It may help protect the liver. Animal studies and a few small human studies suggest hibiscus extract may help the liver handle stress and fat. The human evidence is still limited, so think of this as a possible bonus, not a promise.

It's rich in antioxidants. Hibiscus is high in polyphenols and anthocyanins, natural compounds that help the body manage the wear and tear that comes from poor sleep, alcohol and heavy food.

It contains some vitamin C. Dried hibiscus contains vitamin C, though boiling reduces it. Fresh fruit during the week will do more for your vitamin C than the zobo itself.

It may calm inflammation. Some small studies found lower inflammation markers in people who drank hibiscus regularly. More research is needed, but it fits with how many people say they feel: lighter and less heavy.

WHAT ZOBO WON'T DO

It won't burn fat. It won't "flush toxins" in a magic way; your liver and kidneys do that job every day. And it won't undo a week of party food on its own. It works because it replaces sugary drinks and alcohol and becomes the anchor of a healthier week.

THE SUGAR PROBLEM

This plan uses unsweetened or very lightly sweetened zobo. Party zobo, with a cup of sugar and artificial flavour, gives your body more of exactly what it's recovering from. The sugar is the problem. The zobo is the solution.

The other ingredients

Nigerian zobo is rarely just hibiscus. The additions many families use are good for more than flavour.

Ginger. One of the best-studied natural digestive aids. Research suggests it helps food move through the stomach and eases nausea. In this plan, ginger goes into every batch.

Cloves. Cloves have long been used in traditional medicine for bloating and gas. A few cloves add warmth and flavour, so you need less sweetener.

Pineapple skin (optional). It adds natural sweetness, so you need little or no honey. One honest note: the digestive enzyme in pineapple, bromelain, is destroyed by boiling. If you want its benefit, eat fresh pineapple during the week as well.

CHAPTER 3: The Zobo Reset Recipe

Before Day 1, you need a batch of the right zobo. Not the party version. The reset version: same base, adjusted for the job.

The base recipe (2 to 3 days' supply)

INGREDIENT	AMOUNT AND NOTES
Dried hibiscus (zobo) leaves	2 cups, rinsed well under cold water
Fresh ginger	A thumb-sized piece, peeled and sliced thin
Cloves	5 to 6 whole cloves
Water	1.5 litres for boiling, plus 1 litre to top up after
Pineapple skin	Optional. Skin of half a pineapple, washed well
Sweetener	1 to 2 teaspoons of honey, or nothing. No artificial sweetener during the 7 days

How to make it

Step 1. Rinse the dried zobo leaves under cold water until the water runs clearer. There is often dust and grit on them.

Step 2. Put the ginger, cloves and pineapple skin (if using) into a pot with 1.5 litres of water. Bring to the boil, then add the rinsed zobo leaves.

Step 3. Reduce to medium heat and simmer gently for 15 to 20 minutes. A long, hard boil destroys more of the good compounds.

Step 4. Take it off the heat and let it cool for 10 to 15 minutes. Strain through a sieve into a clean jug or bottle.

Step 5. Add the remaining 1 litre of cold water and your honey, if using. Taste. It should be tart, slightly spicy and refreshing. If it's too strong, add more water.

Step 6. Store it covered in the fridge and make a fresh batch every 2 to 3 days.

KEEP IT SAFE

Use clean, boiled or bottled water and a clean bottle. If your zobo smells sour, tastes fizzy or looks cloudy, it has started to ferment: pour it away and make a new batch. If you don't have a fridge, make a smaller batch each day. Avoid buying street zobo for this plan, because you can't control the sugar or the hygiene.

What you'll drink and when

TIME	AMOUNT	WHY
Morning, before breakfast	250ml	A gentle start for your digestion, and a habit that anchors the day.
30 minutes before lunch	200ml	Many people find it takes the edge off their hunger before the biggest meal.
Evening, before 7pm	200ml	With or after dinner. Not later, or you may wake up at night to urinate.

That's about 650ml of zobo a day. Drink 1.5 to 2 litres of plain water as well.

DO THIS NOW

Write a shopping list: zobo leaves, ginger, cloves, honey, a pineapple, watermelon, cucumber, pawpaw, oats or pap, beans, eggs, fresh fish, leafy vegetables (ugu, waterleaf, bitter leaf, scent leaf). Make your first batch tonight.

CHAPTER 4: The 7-Day Plan

The plan has three phases. Days 1 and 2 are about clearing and resting your digestion. Days 3 to 5 rebuild. Days 6 and 7 steady you, so you can go back to normal eating without undoing your progress.

You will eat. This is not a starvation plan. The goal is to cut back on the foods slowing your recovery and add more of the foods that help.

THE RULES FOR ALL 7 DAYS

No alcohol. No fizzy soft drinks or malt. Cut salt hard: no extra seasoning cubes, go easy on stockfish and Maggi. Drink your zobo at the three times. Drink water in between. Walk for 20 to 30 minutes on at least four of the days. Sleep before midnight if you possibly can.

Day 1: Clear Out

Your digestion is backed up. Today's goal is to keep meals small, light and easy to digest.

TIME	WHAT TO DO
Morning	A glass of warm water with fresh lemon, then your morning zobo 30 minutes later. Breakfast: plain oats with sliced banana, or pap (akamu) with no sugar, plus a boiled egg.
Midday	Pre-lunch zobo. Lunch: vegetable soup with little oil, and a small portion of swallow (eba or amala). Add beans, egg or a piece of fish for protein.
Afternoon	Plain water. Fruit if you're hungry: watermelon, cucumber or orange.
Evening	Evening zobo. Dinner: light pepper soup with fish, or a small bowl of pap. Try not to eat after 8pm.

You may urinate more than usual today. Zobo has a mild diuretic effect, so that's expected. Keep drinking plain water.

Day 2: Reduce and Restore

Same structure as Day 1, with a little more variety. Still light.

TIME	WHAT TO DO
Morning	Warm water, then morning zobo. Breakfast: moi moi with no added salt, or 2 boiled eggs with sliced tomatoes.

TIME	WHAT TO DO
Midday	Pre-lunch zobo. Lunch: lightly made egusi soup (not the party version, heavy with palm oil and stock) with a small wrap of eba, or rice and stew with plenty of vegetables mixed in.
Evening	Evening zobo. Dinner: pepper soup with fish or chicken. Moderate portion. Eat slowly.

Many people start to notice less puffiness around the face and hands by the end of Day 2. The belly often follows a day or two later.

Day 3: Fibre Day

Party eating is low in fibre: white rice, fried food, lots of meat. Fibre keeps your gut moving and feeds the helpful bacteria in it, so today you correct the balance on purpose.

TIME	WHAT TO DO
Morning	Morning zobo. Breakfast: soft beans porridge with plantain, or akara (go easy on the salt).
Midday	Pre-lunch zobo. Lunch: yam porridge with plenty of leafy vegetables, such as ugu, waterleaf or scent leaf. A little palm oil is fine.
Evening	Evening zobo. Dinner: vegetables stir-fried with fish, chicken or eggs, over a small portion of rice or sweet potato.

WHY FIBRE TODAY?

Beans, plantain, yam and leafy greens contain fibre that your gut bacteria feed on. Add fibre gradually and drink plenty of water with it, or it can cause gas of its own.

Day 4: The Midpoint Check

By Day 4, many people notice their clothes fitting a little better, less heaviness after meals and more energy in the mornings. If you haven't noticed any change, check your salt. Hidden salt in seasoning cubes, tomato paste and smoked fish is the usual reason the puffiness hasn't lifted.

TIME	WHAT TO DO
Morning	Morning zobo. Breakfast: a fresh fruit plate with whatever is in season, such as watermelon, pawpaw and pineapple.
Midday	Pre-lunch zobo. Lunch: home-made jollof rice with a fresh tomato and pepper base, less oil and less seasoning than usual, with steamed or grilled fish.

TIME	WHAT TO DO
Evening	Evening zobo. Dinner: bitter leaf soup (ofe onugbu) with a small portion of eba.

If you haven't started walking yet, start today: 20 to 30 minutes. Not a workout, just a walk. Around your estate, to the shop and back, anywhere you'll actually do it. Movement helps your body clear fluid and helps digestion.

Day 5: Energy Rebuild

Today is about eating properly to restore your energy. Don't undereat.

TIME	WHAT TO DO
Morning	Morning zobo. Breakfast: pap with a boiled egg on the side, or eggs scrambled with tomatoes and peppers in very little oil.
Midday	Pre-lunch zobo. Lunch: banga soup with a proper portion of swallow. Palm fruit is rich in vitamin E and beta-carotene.
Evening	Evening zobo. Dinner: grilled fish or chicken with roasted plantain and a fresh salad. Skip the salad cream; use a squeeze of lemon and a little groundnut or olive oil.

Day 6: Normal Eating, With Support

Today you start bringing back your usual meals, more deliberately than before. Smaller portions of salty food. More vegetables on every plate. Keep the zobo schedule.

TIME	WHAT TO DO
Morning	Morning zobo. Breakfast: what you normally eat, such as bread and eggs, akara and pap. Just go easy on the salt.
Midday	Pre-lunch zobo. Lunch: any home-cooked Nigerian meal you want. Notice how your body responds. If you feel heavy afterwards, that tells you something about portion size.
Evening	Evening zobo. Dinner: something light.

Day 7: Complete and Keep Going

Last day. Most people who stay consistent feel noticeably lighter by now: less bloated, more regular, with cleaner morning energy. Today is about finishing well and setting yourself up for what comes next.

TIME	WHAT TO DO
Morning	Morning zobo. Breakfast: something you really enjoy that's also reasonably good for you.
Midday	Pre-lunch zobo. Lunch: a proper Nigerian meal. Eat well and enjoy it.
Evening	Final evening zobo. Dinner: the same as lunch. Eat well, and be grateful for what your body has done in 7 days.

Tonight, before bed, notice how you feel compared with Day 1. Write it in the tracker at the back of this book. That comparison is the whole point.

CHAPTER 5: Foods That Help, and Foods That Slow You Down

A quick reference for any moment in the 7 days when you're not sure about a food.

Foods that support the reset

FOOD	WHY IT HELPS
Watermelon	Over 90% water. Helps you stay hydrated and full on very few calories.
Cucumber	Hydrating and light. A good snack at any time of day.
Pawpaw	Contains papain, a natural enzyme that helps break down protein.
Fresh pineapple	Contains bromelain, a digestive enzyme (eat it fresh; boiling destroys it).
Bitter leaf (onugbu)	Traditionally valued for the liver and digestion, and studied for its antioxidants.
Ugu (pumpkin leaves)	Rich in iron and antioxidants. Good for energy.
Beans	High-fibre protein. Keeps you full and feeds your gut bacteria.
Fresh ginger	Add it to meals and to your zobo. Supports digestion.
Unripe plantain	Less sugar than ripe plantain, with fibre and resistant starch.
Fresh fish	Light, clean protein that's easy to digest.

Foods to cut back for 7 days

FOOD	WHY IT SLOWS RECOVERY
Seasoning cubes	Very high in salt, which keeps water in. Season with fresh tomato, pepper, onion and scent leaf instead.
Alcohol (any kind)	Your liver is recovering. Alcohol adds straight back to its workload.
Fizzy drinks and malt	Add gas and sugar to a system already dealing with both.
Fried food	Heavy to digest. Keep suya, puff puff and oily akara to a minimum.
Packaged snacks	Chin chin and biscuits are high in salt and sugar with almost no fibre.
Large amounts of dairy	Many adults find milk bloating, especially if they are lactose intolerant. Cut back for the week and see.

CHAPTER 6: What to Expect, Day by Day

Knowing what's coming makes it easier to stay consistent. Everybody is different, so treat this as a rough guide, not a promise.

Days 1 and 2

The adjustment phase. You may urinate more, especially after the morning zobo. Your stomach may feel different as your meals change. If you feel dizzy, faint or unwell, stop the zobo, drink plain water and eat a normal meal.

Days 3 and 4

Many people notice visible changes here: less puffiness in the face and hands, a flatter-feeling belly, better sleep and more energy in the mornings.

Days 5 and 6

Energy is usually back. Digestion feels more regular. Clothes fit better. Some people find their cravings for large portions settle down.

Day 7

You should feel close to how you felt before the celebrations started. Not a new body: your body back. That's a full reset.

Common questions

Can I continue after Day 7? Many people keep one glass of zobo each morning as a habit. Keep it moderate: one glass a day, not litres. The 7 days are the intensive part; after that it's maintenance.

What if I miss a day? Start again the next day. A missed day doesn't erase your progress. Just don't let one missed day become three.

Will I lose weight? Some people see the scale drop by a kilo or two over the week, but that is mostly water your body was holding on to, not fat. This is a reset, not a weight-loss plan. If you want to lose fat, the habits in Chapter 7 are a good start.

Can my teenage daughter do it? The food part of the plan is healthy for the whole family. For anyone under 18, skip the three-times-a-day zobo schedule and just cut the soft drinks, salt and fried food.

I'm pregnant, breastfeeding, or on medicine. Can I do this? Please read the warning box in *Before You Start* and speak to your doctor first.

CHAPTER 7: Keeping the Habits After Day 7

The 7 days are the intensive phase. What you do after decides how long the results last.

You didn't build up that bloating and sluggishness in one meal. It built up over days of celebration. Your reset worked because you changed your daily choices for 7 days. Keeping the results means keeping a few of those changes, not all of them. Just the ones that make the biggest difference.

The three habits worth keeping

1. Morning zobo or warm water with lemon. Starting your day with a glass of unsweetened zobo or warm water, before you eat anything, is the simplest habit in this book. It takes 60 seconds and reminds you every morning that you're looking after yourself. If you keep only one thing, keep this.

2. One meal a day with serious vegetables. Nigerian food is full of vegetables: ugu, waterleaf, bitter leaf, ewedu, scent leaf. Party eating and convenience eating push them off the plate. Make sure at least one meal every day has a proper portion of them.

3. Go easy on the salt outside celebrations. Seasoning cubes aren't evil. Using them at full strength in every meal, every day, is where the problem lives. Try halving the amount in your everyday cooking. Your taste buds will adjust within a couple of weeks, and your blood pressure will thank you.

KEEP THIS GUIDE HANDY

Your social calendar is busy all year: Eid, Easter, Christmas, wedding season, owambe weekends. Any time your body needs a reset after a stretch of celebrating, make a fresh batch of zobo and start again from Day 1.

CLOSING: You Already Had the Answer

There's something worth noticing about this whole plan.

The drink at the centre of it has been in Nigerian kitchens for generations. Your grandmother knew how to make it. Your mother probably made it for celebrations, for illness, for no reason at all. The ginger, the cloves, the pineapple were added long before any scientist studied them.

You didn't need an imported detox tea with ingredients you can't pronounce, shipped from a country that doesn't know what suya is. You needed someone to explain, plainly, how to use the drink you already trust, with intention, alongside the food you already eat.

Whether the celebration that brought you here was Christmas, Eid, Easter, a three-day wedding or an owambe that somehow stretched into a full week, seven days of sensible eating, water, sleep and properly made zobo will help bring your body back. It's not magic. It's your body doing what bodies do when you stop fighting them and start supporting them.

And the next time the owambe calls, you go. You enjoy every bit of it. Then you come home, make your zobo, and reset.

Go make your batch. Day 1 starts tomorrow morning.

QUICK REFERENCE: The Zobo Reset at a Glance

Every day for 7 days

- Morning zobo: 250ml before breakfast
- Pre-lunch zobo: 200ml, 30 minutes before eating
- Evening zobo: 200ml, before 7pm
- Plain water: 1.5 to 2 litres through the day
- A 20 to 30 minute walk on at least four days
- Sleep before midnight

The three phases

- **Days 1 and 2, Clear Out:** light meals, lots of water.
- **Days 3 to 5, Rebuild:** fibre, leafy vegetables, proper portions.
- **Days 6 and 7, Steady:** back to normal meals, keep the zobo.

Eat more of

- Watermelon, cucumber, pawpaw, fresh pineapple
- Beans, unripe plantain, yam
- Bitter leaf, ugu, waterleaf, ewedu
- Fresh fish, eggs, chicken
- Fresh ginger

Cut for the week

- Alcohol of every kind
- Fizzy drinks and malt
- Extra seasoning cubes and salty additions
- Deep-fried food and packaged snacks

Recipe card

- 2 cups dried zobo leaves, rinsed
- A thumb of ginger, sliced, and 5 to 6 cloves
- Pineapple skin (optional)
- Simmer in 1.5 litres of water for 15 to 20 minutes
- Strain and top up with 1 litre of cold water

- Sweeten lightly (1 to 2 teaspoons of honey at most)
- Keep in the fridge; make a fresh batch every 2 to 3 days

Your 7-day tracker

Tick each box as you go, and write one word for how you feel each evening.

DAY	ZOBO ×3	WATER	WALK	HOW I FEEL
Day 1	☐ ☐ ☐	☐	☐ |	
Day 2	☐ ☐ ☐	☐	☐ |	
Day 3	☐ ☐ ☐	☐	☐ |	
Day 4	☐ ☐ ☐	☐	☐ |	
Day 5	☐ ☐ ☐	☐	☐ |	
Day 6	☐ ☐ ☐	☐	☐ |	
Day 7	☐ ☐ ☐	☐	☐ |	

IMPORTANT

This book is general information for healthy adults and is not medical advice. Research on hibiscus is still developing, and individual results vary. If you are pregnant, breastfeeding, taking any medicine or have a health condition, speak to a doctor before starting.

The Honest Body